

Estonia

 The smallest and most northerly of the Baltic states, Estonia has a long coastline and beautiful scenery that attracts many tourists from Finland and Scandinavia. Under Soviet rule, its rural economy was transformed. It is now an industrial nation, and most people live in towns. Estonians are closely related to Finns and speak a similar language.

ESTONIA FACTS

CAPITAL CITY	Tallinn
AREA	45,125 sq km (17,423 sq miles)
POPULATION	1,400,000
MAIN LANGUAGES	Estonian, Russian
MAJOR RELIGION	Christian
CURRENCY	Kroon



Tourism

More than one million tourists visit Estonia every year. The medieval buildings of Tallinn, Estonia's capital, are a major attraction, with a wealth of historical monuments. Summer regattas and boating and yachting in the sheltered waters of the Gulf of Riga are also popular.



Flax stems are used to make linen fabric and ropes.

Flax

Textiles made from flax and cotton are among Estonia's leading exports. Flax is harvested at different times for various purposes: young green stems make fine cloth called linen; tougher fibres are used for ropes and mats.

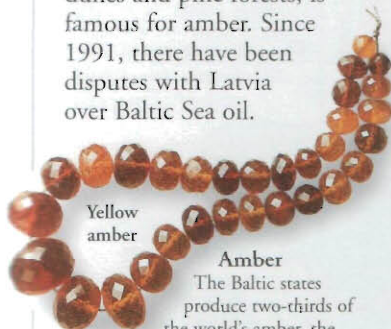
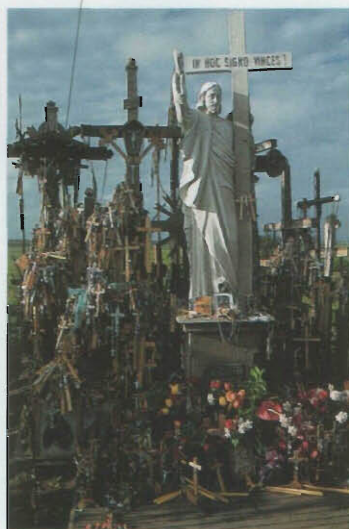
Lithuania

 Once a powerful nation, ruling lands that extended to the Black Sea, Lithuania sits south of Latvia. Most people live in the interior of the country, working in industry or farming. The short coastline, fringed with sand dunes and pine forests, is famous for amber. Since 1991, there have been disputes with Latvia over Baltic Sea oil.

LITHUANIA FACTS

CAPITAL CITY	Vilnius
AREA	65,200 sq km (25,174 sq miles)
POPULATION	3,782,000
MAIN LANGUAGES	Lithuanian, Russian
MAJOR RELIGION	Christian
CURRENCY	Litas

Hill of Crosses, near Siauliai, a shrine to honour the dead.



Yellow amber

Amber

The Baltic states produce two-thirds of the world's amber, the fossilized sap of pine trees. Amber is used to make jewellery in shades of yellow, orange, and deep gold.

Religion

By contrast to Estonians and Latvians, who are mainly Protestants, Lithuanians are mostly Roman Catholics. They managed to keep their faith even under Soviet rule, which discouraged religion.

Latvia

 Sandwiched in a central position between Estonia and Lithuania, Latvia is a flat country with about 12,000 rivers. Manufacturing, encouraged under Soviet rule, is the basis of the economy. Like the other states in this region, Latvia suffered high inflation during the 1990s. Farming, fishing, and timber are valuable sources of income.

LATVIA FACTS

CAPITAL CITY	Riga
AREA	64,589 sq km (24,938 sq miles)
POPULATION	2,400,000
MAIN LANGUAGES	Latvian, Russian
MAJOR RELIGION	Christian
CURRENCY	Lat



Farming

Latvia has a larger area of fertile land than the other Baltic states. Since independence, the huge state farms introduced by the Russians have been dismantled and are now privately owned. Most are dairy farms.

People

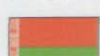
About one-third of Latvians are of Russian origin and there are smaller numbers of Ukrainians and



Women wear traditional costumes in Latvia's Rites of Spring Festival.

Belarusians. Just over half the population are ethnic Letts, or Latvians, who cling to their cultural heritage. They celebrate many traditional and religious festivals.

Belarus

 Land-locked, and with few natural resources, Belarus suffers great poverty. In 1986, an accident at the Chernobyl nuclear reactor in the Ukraine severely contaminated farmland. Many areas remain unsafe. The shaky economy is based on the manufacture of machines, cars, chemicals, and a large farming sector. Unlike the other Baltic states, Belarus has maintained close political and economic ties with Russia and is taking steps to set up a union.

BELARUS FACTS

CAPITAL CITY	Minsk
AREA	207,600 sq km (80,154 sq miles)
POPULATION	10,320,000
MAIN LANGUAGES	Belarusian, Russian
MAJOR RELIGION	Christian
CURRENCY	Belarusian rouble



Ceramics

Belarus produces many beautifully crafted ceramic and porcelain items, such as vases and ornaments. The country is also known for its high-quality decorated glassware, made by heating sand with salt, limestone, and old glass, then moulding the molten liquid glass.

Food

The national dish of Belorussia is *draniki*, made from fried, grated potatoes, and served with sour cream and pickled berries or beetroot. Soup made from beetroot is also a popular dish.



Draniki



Sour cream

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